

Hugh Hancock,
Chariman,
Strange Company

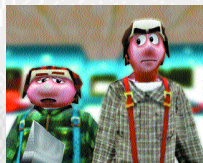
“I don't think that there are any specific show-stopping reasons why Machinima shouldn't achieve a very high profile”

handful of pioneers across the globe, Machinima is life, their calling. The ingredients involved are deceptively simple: a storyboard to flesh out the characters, models and 'props' duly sculpted with the help of 3D modelling tools such as 3D Studio Max, which also serves to create basic animations for the characters involved. The raw materials are then brought together within a game engine of choice and the movie is acted out by either AI bots or 'puppeteers' who control digital avatars. Add the dialogue and music, follow it with

some live editing, and the movie is done! Hugh Hancock, the Artistic Director at Strange Company, has this to say about the benefits of his trade: "In a lot of ways Machinima acts as a combination of the best things about live-action filming, puppetry and CGI (Computer Generated Images). Like film, production is fast and fluid, and there is plenty of possibility to experiment with techniques, different interpretations of the script and ways of shooting. Unlike film, however, Machinima has most of the advantages of animation too: it's possible to change any aspect of any shot down to the finest detail to replay a shot exactly as it was originally created, while making changes to the camera or actor-setup as you go, to shoot a film anywhere you can imagine—the list goes on!"

The technique is slowly gaining popularity as a viable alternative to traditional CG animation. Machinima movies (generally filmed with the *Half-Life* and *Quake II* engine) range from the bizarrely violent *Comedy in Armour*, to the surreal *Ozymandias* and the hilarious *Hardly Workin'*. Moreover, the budget-sensitive game-development industry has also taken notice of this art form. Thus expensive CG cut-scenes have been upstaged by Machinima story-telling techniques, as demonstrated by *Half-Life* and *Metal Gear Solid 2*.

BEHIND THE SCENES



HARDLY WORKIN'

éing: John Olinyk as Larry Lumberjack, Matt Dominianni as Lenny Lumberjack and Paul Jannicola as Cook Carl

It took the ILL Clan nine months of hard work to create this award-winning film. Here's a recap of what went into it:

Pre-production: The motley crew wanted to have Lenny and Larry visit a diner run by Cook Carl, a character from their previous brain storming sessions. To get a skeleton story in place, they used a process made famous by Chuck Jones of *Loony Tunes* fame. As a group, they came up with 'business'; funny bits that they wanted the characters to do. The best businesses were collected and the director and writers put them into a basic storyline. Story boards were then drawn and used to create timed 'animatics'.

Character models were created in 3D Studio Max, Nichimen's Nendo and Q2 Modeler. They were given basic animations that were later bound to hot keys by the puppeteers. Objects and a map of the diner were created using Quark Army Knife. All this was then packed together for use by the *Quake II* engine.

No dialogue was written beforehand, just plot and story points. The improvisers then recorded dialogue based on the storyline, allowing for a lot of freedom for comic material to be generated by the group. The funniest takes were edited together into what became the final sound file, using the animatics as a guide.

Production: A local area network was set up with a computer for each character used in a scene. The Clan had at the most four character computers and one camera/server machine from which the scenes were shot. A basic camera configuration file was created that allowed the camera to float and keys were bound to zoom in and change its tracking speed. All the scenes were recorded in *Quake II* as demo files.

Each puppeteer bound a set of keys for their characters' basic animation. The sound file for each scene was played back on DAT tape; the puppeteers could thus match the dialogue. The shoot was run just like a film set, with 'rolling', 'action' and 'cut' being called. As needed, props were tweaked beforehand for each scene.

Post Production: Select takes were dumped to MiniDV and a basic edit put together in Final Cut Pro. A shareware called Key Grip II was then used to 'recam', a technique to create and adjust camera angles for a scene after it is shot. This aspect of Machinima is great because the group only had to shoot a master shot during production. Other angles could be recammed afterwards—this was like being able to re-shoot a scene without having to bring the whole crew and cast back. Tweaking the character animation and the time-consuming process of lip-synching also happened in post production.

The team looked at the rough edit and realised that it needed more explanation, so they recorded the Grind-O-Matic commercial segment. Titles and end credits were finally added, and the movie was done!

